WHO TAUGHT THE MACHINE?

PAYSLIP · DATA LABELER · KENYA

Hours this shift	9
Passages labeled	150–250
Hourly take-home	**$1.32–$2.00**
Billed to client	$12.50 / hr

Figures reported by TIME, 2023

THE INVISIBLE WORK BEHIND EVERY "SAFE" CHATBOT ANSWER

a zine by Jake Tempesta

DH 101 · Denison · Nov 2026

First, somebody has to tell it what things are.

Data labeling means tagging images, text, and audio so a model can learn. Scale AI, for example, has paid workers to draw boxes around pedestrians and dogs in street photos (Fortune, 2025). Researchers Mary Gray and Siddharth Suri call it **ghost work**: real labor, designed to be hidden.

LABEL LOG · batch 0412

image_0412.jpg	pedestrian	✓ human
image_0413.jpg	dog	✓ human
text_88213	hate speech	✓ human
text_88214	violence	✓ human
text_88215	???	waiting

Illustrative example, not real data.

EVERY "✓ HUMAN" IS A PERSON READING IT. ALL DAY.

TIME reported that OpenAI paid a firm called Sama to have workers in Kenya label the worst text on the internet, to make ChatGPT "less toxic."

Who is actually doing this?

OpenAI

the brand you know

pays $12.50/hr

Sama

SF firm. Workers in Kenya, Uganda, India.
"ethical AI"

$1.32–$2



≈ 36 workers · 3 teams

They aren't OpenAI employees. They work for a **middleman**. TIME reviewed hundreds of pages of documents, including payslips, and talked to four Sama employees. All four asked to stay anonymous.

Their three teams each handled one topic: sexual abuse, hate speech, or violence.

What a shift looks like.

SHIFT SHEET	
Shift length	**9 hours**
Passages (workers say)	**150–250**
Passages (Sama target)	70
Words per passage	**100–1,000+**
Topics	3 topics

"You will read a number of statements like that all through the week."

— a Sama worker, quoted in TIME

All four workers TIME spoke to said the job left them mentally scarred. They called wellness sessions rare and unhelpful. **Sama says** staff could see licensed therapists, one-on-one or in groups, at any time.

+ on Mechanical Turk, a median 33% of working time is unpaid (searching for tasks, etc.) — Toxtli et al., 2021

Who got paid?

THE SAFE-CHATBOT SHOP
receipt for one "less toxic" AI

OpenAI → Sama, hourly rate	$12.50
Worker take-home, hourly	**$1.32-2.00**
(Sama says: $1.46-3.74)	
3 OpenAI-Sama contracts	~$200,000
Meta → 49% of Scale AI	**$14.3 BILLION**
Scale AI valuation	>$29 BILLION
MTurk median wage	~$2.00 / hr
MTurk pay over $7.25/hr	4%

Worker share of the billing rate:
about 1/10 to 1/6.

Sama says $12.50 covered infrastructure, salaries, and benefits. Meta and Scale AI are different companies from OpenAI and Sama, but sit in the same layer of the AI supply chain. Sources: TIME 2023; Hara et al. 2018; Fortune 2025.

THANK YOU FOR SHOPPING. YOU WERE NOT ON THE RECEIPT.

Memo: the cis-tem of AI

CONFIDENTIAL

TO: anyone who uses a chatbot
FROM: the system
RE: what you aren't meant to notice

Mar Hicks reminds us systems have assumptions built in. Ask: **who built it? who is it for? who is left out of the picture?**

How the labor stays invisible:

1. Distance. Work runs through middlemen, away from the brand.

2. Branding. Sama calls itself "ethical AI." Pay: $1.32–$2.

3. Interface. The answer has one clean voice. Author: [redacted]

4. Unpaid time. A third of Turk time is never paid.

VALUE MOVES UP THE CHAIN: LABELS → MODELS → VALUATIONS. THE PEOPLE WHO MADE THE LABELS GET PAID IN CENTS.

Making this labor visible is a political act. On a football team the highlight reel shows one play. Nobody posts the 200th rep. In AI, the chatbot is the highlight. They are the reps.

TO DO: MAKE IT VISIBLE

- [ ] **Ask where the labels came from.** When a company says its AI is "safe," ask who made it safe and what they were paid.

- [ ] **Read and pass on the reporting.** Start with TIME's Kenya investigation and Gray and Suri's *Ghost Work*.

- [ ] **Check the ratings.** Oxford's Fairwork project scores cloudwork platforms on pay, conditions, and contracts.

- [ ] **Credit the labor.** When you cite AI in your own work, remember it was built on people's work, and say so.

- [ ] **Back fair terms up front.** Pay, contracts, and mental health care settled before the work starts, not after the lawsuit.

THE MACHINE DIDN'T TEACH ITSELF.

Sources

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Credits

Made by Jake Tempesta, DH 101, Denison University, Nov. 2026. No photographs: all graphics are AI-generated code (HTML/CSS/SVG) by Claude (Anthropic). Tools: Claude; Playwright (PDF export). Fonts: Special Elite, Permanent Marker, Courier Prime (SIL OFL / Apache 2.0). Dollar figures are as reported by TIME; Sama disputes some, and both sides are shown.

NOW GO ASK WHO TAUGHT THE MACHINE.